Dulles-Nehru meeting also seemed less trenchant than three years before. Dulles described the conversations as “intimate and animated and informal”; the Indian prime minister called them “long and frank.” Both policymakers offered assurances and explanations on key subjects of concern to the other (Goa, Pakistan, the Soviet Union). Dulles also passed on Eisenhower’s invitation for Nehru to visit the US, which the prime minister seemed inclined to accept.[308] Before that visit would take place in December, a number of changes would occur, including in how the two countries perceived and sought to deal with China and each other.

Mutual need and the reality that neither could ignore the other had kept the US-India relationship from deteriorating into hostility or total indifference. But between 1949 and 1956, that need had not been sufficient to overcome their major differences in attitudes and approaches toward key issues, including China. Moreover, the two countries had not developed the habits of cooperation that allowed the US, for example, to overcome policy differences—especially, but not solely, on China—with countries like Britain. American and Indian policymakers had limited historical experience interacting with each other. And as Dulles told Pandit, “Trust is built up over a period of time.”[309] At times, the governments were willing, albeit grudgingly, to give the other the benefit of the doubt, but this was not common. Simultaneously, however, in each country expectations of the other were—perhaps unrealistically—high. Many in the US expected India to play a role in their Cold War script. After all, it was a noncommunist democracy faced with a communist threat at its doorstep. On the other hand, many in India expected the US to understand India’s perspective. After all, it was a fellow postcolonial democracy that had advocated for India’s independence and had itself experienced the desire not to become entangled in power politics.[310] But when these expectations went unfulfilled, it had only increased the disillusionment.